to finds in China and Thailand, suggesting a shared material culture or the existence of a vast trade network across prehistoric Southeast Asia.

The first millennium BCE brought about profound social, economic, and political change. Clusters of villages evolved into cities as trade networks created wealth. This, in turn, led to the development of ever more complex societies in Myanmar as agricultural production coupled with the introduction of iron gave rise to urbanization. The first cities emerged independently of each other along the coastline of the Ayeyarwaddy basin in Lower Myanmar and the seasonal tributary rivers of the central plains of Upper Myanmar. The cities were well planned using a combination of indigenous and Indian building techniques. Sacral buildings were constructed using nonperishable materials such as fired brick covered with plaster and sandstone, while secular buildings were built of wood. The use of brick and sandstone in the construction of pagodas and temples was both structural and symbolic. Architecturally, bricks were needed to support and reinforce the pagodas tall cylindrical plinths. By using a structural framing system builders were able to reinforce the framed outer walls. Symbolically, the lavish and massive pagodas and temples reflected both royal piety and temporal power. Timber was used by the general populace because it was both affordable and allowed the construction of buildings according to the various requirements and needs of its owners.

The Mon were the first civilization to emerge in Lower Myanmar. They settled in the Ayeyarwaddy River delta and along the Toninthayi coast. The Mon blended Indian and Mon culture together in a hybrid culture of the two civilizations. The Mon did not remain the sole occupants of Myanmar for long. Another group called the Pyū made their way from the eastern Himalayas of the Tibetan Plateau to the northwestern Ayeyarwaddy valley sometime the first century BCE.

By 300 CE, the Burmans are thought to have made their way to Myanmar from the Tibetan Plateau in northwestern China. By 800 CE, the Burmans had replaced the Pyū as the dominant group in the Ayeyarwaddy River delta and surrounding areas. By the middle of the ninth century CE, the Mons had come to dominate much of Lower Myanmar.

THE ANYATHIAN CULTURE